

to a smaller player component called 'mini-me'. There is also a full-screen mode, and a Party mode when your PC turns into a DJ.

The first time the program runs, it brings up a dialog box to search for media on your hard disk. The search is comprehensive—it finds all the media types you specify—not just MP3s, but images and videos too. It's best to stick to MP3, and any other format you store your music in. Avoid searching for JPEG and other media files, or you will end up with thousands of tiny files from all over your hard disk.

Media Center 9 flexes its organizing muscle in the form of Smart Lists. These are automatically generated play lists, based on certain criteria. For example, you could ask to hear some of your favourites

Artist	Album	Rating	Track	Duration	Bit
id	Red Hot Chili Peppers	Blood Sugar Sex Magik	32	4:04	12
id	112	From Inner Experience	31	4:04	12
id	of the Tigua		30	4:05	12
id	et DJ Dreams	Billy Joel	29	4:05	12
id	Touch the He...	Byron Adams	28	4:05	12
id	the Hip	cyfrc dian	27	4:05	12
id	ent Step Lovin'		26	4:06	12
id	Baker	Love For Sale	25	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	24	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	23	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	22	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	21	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	20	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	19	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	18	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	17	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	16	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	15	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	14	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	13	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	12	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	11	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	10	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	9	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	8	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	7	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	6	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	5	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	4	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	3	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	2	4:06	12
id	en To Innocence	Enigma	1	4:06	12

The smart single-click rating system

that you haven't heard recently. It knows which songs are your favourites because you can assign ratings to each song. I know what your thinking—how am I ever going to rate thousands of songs? All you have to do is click the number of stars you want to assign to the song in the media list. So, it's just one click per song, and you can do this while listening to music. Doing a few at a time will get your collection in shape pretty quick. The ratings, combined with the Smart Lists, will really make your listening more enjoyable.

Using its listing capabilities, you can see all the files of a particular artiste placed together. You can even move all the files into one folder on your disk. This comes handy when you want to use another program to manage your tunes, or burn CDs.

Media Center 9 also has a built-in CD-Burning and CD-Ripping. By default, songs are ripped into the Ogg Vorbis format. If you want to rip directly into MP3, you need an additional component. This can be downloaded at

<http://www.musicex.com/cgi-bin/downloads/mcplugins.pl>. In Options, you will also find that you can automatically perform normalisation whilst ripping tracks from the CD.

While Media Center is the most feature-rich software here, the wealth of features detracts from its usability, and makes finding some options and tasks difficult.

Zortam MP3 Media Studio

The first thing you notice about Zortam Media Studio is its speedy installation—a few clicks, and a few seconds later, it's done. However, things slow down considerably, once you start working with it. The first time we ran it, we were greeted with multiple windows on top of each other. Each one obviously had a different function, and was titled accordingly, but we didn't know where to begin.

The place to begin is the 'Search Media' button in the top left of the main interface. This enables you to search your drives for music files. The search took a fair amount of time, and found all the MP3s on our PC—even the ones on the CD that was in the drive at the time. The files found are displayed in a huge table that has fields for Artiste, Title, and the other typical ID3 Tag fields. This tool's core competency is the powerful renaming and tagging available. The bottom third of the screen is a dedicated renaming zone. When you select a song in the main list, the file's ID3 version2 (ID3v2) information is displayed on the left, and ID3 version1 (ID3v1) information is displayed on the right. You can click on any field, and edit it there itself. You can copy tags between ID3v1 and ID3v2. There is also a synchronisation option that works effectively most of the time.

The database maintains all the requisite information: Artiste, track name, etc., and can be exported to an HTML or text file. Zortam also allows ripping a CD to various qualities of MP3, and Wave format. It also does conversions between Wave and MP3.

Advanced MP3 Catalog Pro

This is a no-frills tool, designed simply for cataloguing. It is, by far, the simplest looking tabbed interface tool reviewed

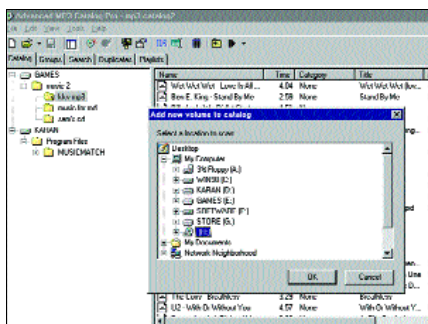
Sound Beginning and Perfect Ending

Sometimes, when recording off an old tape that your friend had recorded in his sleep a long time back, you will find that a song may begin half way or be cut off at the end. Whilst regenerating the beginning or end is not possible, you can cleverly cover it up, and make it sound less disturbing. The simplest thing we could do is fade in, or out. Depending upon whether you wish to fade in, or fade out, select the first, or last, few seconds of a song. Go to **Effects > Amplitude > Amplify**. Click on the fade tab.

Set the initial amplification to the minimum value to fade in. To fade out, set the Final Amplification to the minimum. If you're feeling a bit more adventurous, and don't mind spending some time experimenting, CEP can do some neat stuff. Try the Pitch Bender (**Effects > Time/Pitch**) with the Preset 'Turntable loosing power' for a cool ending.

here. The first tab is the Catalog where you can see your entire collection sorted into Volumes—based on the location of your songs—much like separate drives in windows. The left pane displays these and their subfolders, in a Windows Explorer-like tree.

You can click the New icon to make a new catalogue. As soon as you do so, you will be prompted to scan your PC for MP3 files, or to add a new volume manually.



Add each of your CDs as a volume

The first time you run the program, you should complete a full scan. Once the scan is complete, you can rename the volumes created for your convenience.